A Textile Journey in Southern India

Routing: Pondicherry-Chennai-Bangalore-Mysore-Wayanad-Calicut

Detailed Itinerary

Day 1 **Overseas Departure**

Fly to Chennai.

Day 2 **Chennai – Pondicherry**

Arrive at Chennai airport in the morning, where you will be met and transferred to your hotel in Pondicherry, about three hours away. Stay for three nights at Residency Towers, a first-class property located between Pondicherry's French and Indian quarters, making it convenient for exploring both areas. The hotel offers a choice of dining options and modern facilities, including a spa and swimming pool. The rest of the day is at leisure.

Day 3 **Pondicherry**

Morning explore the French quarters in one of the traditional modes of transports in the town, cycle-rickshaw! This is a great way of seeing this fascinating city and you cover different areas in the town on your journey. The tour will be for a couple of hours. Visit Atelier Shanti a rehabilitation center where women engage in various textile related activities including dying yarn, weaving, embroidery etc. They also produce high quality cotton material at very reasonable prices.Afternoon visit the Cluny Embroidery unit run by the Sisters of Cluny. This is a charity run by the Cluny Convent to support destitute women of the area and they train and employ them here. They make high end handmade embroidery items like napkins, table cloths, bed sheets etc. We could also arrange a short workshop on embroidery here.

Day 4 **Pondicherry**

Morning you visit a textile unit in Auroville to see the use of natural dyes and ancient dyeing art for the modern textile industry. Colours of Nature was founded in 1993, producing 100% eco- friendly natural dyed textiles. The unit specializes in the natural indigo dyeing fermentation technique. You could experiment with painting on fabric with natural colours. They will provide the fabric and raw materials required for the workshop. You will have an opportunity to stitch shibori designs and also prepare samples for tie dyeing and clamping prior to dyeing in indigo vats.

Day 5 **Pondicherry - Chennai**

Drive to Chennai in the morning (3-4 hours). En-route you could visit monuments at Mahabalipuram and Dakshin Chitra.

On arrival in Chennai check-into the GRT Grand.Residency Towers **f**or 2 nights, a modern comfortable hotel in the heart of the city.

Day 6 **Chennai**

Today morning you will visit **Kalakshetra** for a Kalamkari workshop. Spread over almost 100 acres by the seashore in Chennai, the Kalakshetra Foundation, as it is known today, is a vital centre for the study and performance of fine arts, envisioned and designed with the style and proportion of Indian aesthetics.

Remainder of the day at leisure.

Day 7 **Chennai - Bangalore**

Early in the morning you will be transferred to the railway station to board on Shatabti Express to Bangalore . Stay at The Paul for 2 nights, a modern, tastefully dome apartment hotel for 2 nights.

Day 8 **Bangalore**

On this day of workshop at Tharangini you will learn about the history and types of block printing from around India, review of techniques, including what you need to know to do it at home, colour preparation using natural gum resin and vegetable dyes, review of discharge (reactive) block printing using resin paste. You can also print on an indigo dyed pure silk stole with discharge natural resin paste (reactive/discharge printing) which is a very unique 12-step process. Post lunch, you will print on silks with natural dye. Here you can use various layouts and explore multi-colour block prints, after printing the stoles are rolled in newspaper and cooked in steam for several hours overnight.

Day 9 **Bangalore – Mysore**

Drive to Mysore in the morning (4 – 5 hrs). En-route you will be visiting the Government silk cocoon market at Ramnagara, Srirangapatnam and Ranganthittu Bird Sanctuary.

On arrival in Mysore check-into the Metropole Hotel, a comfortable heritage property and former royal guesthouse, for 3 nights.

Remainder of the day at leisure.

Day 10 **Mysore**

The day will be a complete study of silk. Mysore is famous for its silk industry and from the days of the Maharajas. You drive out to a village on the outskirts where silk farming still happens using the traditional methods. You will be shown the process right from the hatching of the worms to the production of the fabric. You will also visit the Government silk factory in the afternoon to see how it is now commercially produced.

Day 11 **Mysore**

Morning enjoy a tour of Mysore and in the afternoon visit Devaraja Market and Mysore Palace.

Evening visit the Devaraja Fruit and vegetable market.

Day 12 **Mysore – Wayanad**

Drive to Wayanad in the morning (5 hours). Stay at After the Rains for 2 nights. This is an organic coffee plantation in the hills of Wayanad. The views from the property of the hills of Ooty and the forests of Nilambur is lovely and the area is also good for walks.

Afternoon enjoy a walk in the plantation where you can get see how the various crops are grown, harvested and processed. It is also a great place for birding as it borders the Nilambur forests.

Day 13 **Wayanad**

Morning visit Uravu, a not for profit bamboo based developmental organisation that strives for rural empowerment through sustainable solutions. Established in 1996, Uravu works with people, governments and businesses to facilitate initiatives with the prime motives of sustainable development and implements focused end to end programs in bamboo sector. A workshop will be arranged where you will have the opportunity to learn more about the way they work and you would get a hands on experience.

Day 14 **Wayanad-Kozhikode (Calicut)**

After breakfast drive to Calicut (3 hours) Stay at the Kadavu Resort for 3 nights. Kadavu is a deluxe property by the riverside with lovely views of the water. The property has a choice of restaurants, modern facilities and landscaped gardens with a good pool. It's a great place to unwind after a hectic day and also good for the airport and visits to the city.

Afternoon visit the local market in Calicut famous for it's local produce.

Days 15 & 16 **30 & 31 March 2022** **Thu & Fri** **Kozhikode (Calicut)**

Full day workshops at Tasara, Beypore. TASARA - an Institution dedicated to creative weaving, is situated In Beypore, a short drive from your hotel. Founded in 1989, Tasara (weaver's shuttle in Sanskrit) is an extension of Spider Weavers, which was established in 1977 .The Centre endeavors to deliver a contemporary touch to this age old form of art, by bringing together artists and weavers in an inspiring ambience, enabling both to break through the limitations of their own mediums. The workshop will be mainly on multi Batik. The Batiks produced at Tasara is well known in textile circles.

Day 17 **1 April 2022** **Saturday** **Kozhikode - UK**

You will be transferred to the airport early morning to check-in for your return flight. The airport is about 45 minutes drive from the hotel.

Meal Plan: Bed & Breakfast (Lunch during the workshops are included)

Included in the price

- All internal road travel by private chauffeur driven large van (air-conditioned) for the main tour.
- Monument entrances & guided sightseeing as per itinerary
- English speaking accompanying guide for the full tour
- Workshops at Kalashetra, Cluny Embroidery,Colours of Nature, Tharangini and Tasara Beypore as mentioned in the itinerary
- Currently applicable Government taxes
- Accommodation as mentioned in the itinerary on double/twin share or single occupancy

(Please note, check-in/check-out is normally 12 noon/2 PM and 10 AM respectively; early check-in/late check-out will be requested but cannot be guaranteed.)

Excluded: International & Internal tickets, Visa fees for India, Insurance, Meals not specified,Sightseeing and Entrances that are not part of the scheduled program, Personal expenses such as laundry, telephone, tips, camera fees etc.